

William Li has struggled with the label "hero" since helping his neighbours escape the fire which engulfed the Hong Kong block of flats he had called home since birth.

Instead, he is haunted by guilt that he could have saved more people from the blaze at Wang Fuk Court, which left at least 159 people dead.

"My heart breaks every time someone calls me a hero," says the 40-year-old, breaking down in tears.

A week on from the disaster, firefighters are still combing the complex of seven burnt-out high rises for the remains of 30 of Mr Li's neighbours - people who, like him, had the misfortune to be at home when the deadly fire began.

What caused the fire to start, and why more people did not escape, is now the subject of an independent committee's investigation, ordered by Hong Kong's chief executive.

Already, it has been revealed that non-fire resistant netting had been fitted around the building, and the fire alarms were not working properly.